

SECTION FIVE

GOVERNMENT, POWER & LAW

Who holds power? How did they get it? What laws govern your world? These questions matter because political structures create the obstacles, stakes, and pressures that shape your characters' choices.

The Iron Cage Principle

The political system in your world should function as an iron cage around your romance. Not a backdrop. Not a setting. A cage.

An iron cage means your characters can see right through the bars and reach right through the bars to touch or even hold onto one another. But they can't get out without breaking something, and when something breaks, there will be repercussions that extend far beyond the two of them. The cage is the law that forbids their union. The war that puts them on opposite sides. The court that watches their every move. The prophecy that demands they sacrifice each other for the realm.

What separates an iron cage from simply a barrier is that the cage doesn't care about the feelings of your characters. A personal obstacle, like a fear of vulnerability, can be worked through with patience and emotional growth. An iron cage can't be talked away. The law doesn't soften because they're in love. The political marriage doesn't dissolve because they've had a meaningful conversation. The court's surveillance doesn't pause because they need a private moment.

The greatest romantasy stories use the cage to accomplish two things simultaneously. It creates the external pressure that makes the romance dangerous, and it creates the forced proximity that makes the romance inevitable. Your couple is stuck in the same cage together. That's why they fall in love, and that's why falling in love is the riskiest action they could take.

Every decision in this section should serve the cage. When you choose a government type, you're choosing what the bars are made of. When you define your laws, you're deciding how strong those bars are. When you build your court, you're designing the space inside the cage where your characters must find each other while the world watches.

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question in this section will apply to your story. Skip what doesn't serve you.

If politics is background in your book, keep it simple. Not every romantasy needs complex political intrigue. Develop just enough to make the world feel real.

And politics can stay vague! Some stories work better with political structures that are felt rather than detailed. That's completely fine.

Quick Guide to What You Need

Every story needs: A form of government, who holds power, and what laws affect your characters.

If your romance is forbidden by law: Focus on How Laws Work and Law Enforcement & Justice.

If your story involves political marriage or court intrigue: Focus on Political Arrangements and Court Politics.

If your characters are on opposing sides: Focus on Warfare & Military and Enemies to Lovers.

If you're not sure yet: Start with the Brain Dump and Forms of Government. You can always come back.

How to Use This Section

Questions marked ♦ **Core** are the foundations. Answer these first and you'll have a working political system. Everything else lets you go deeper. If you're short on time, the Core questions alone will get you writing.

Brain Dump: Your Political World

Before diving into specifics, get your initial vision down. Don't overthink this. Just write what you already see.

What do you already know about the political world of your story?

Jot down anything: a throne, a war, a forbidden law, a court, rival nations, an uprising. Whatever is already in your head, no matter how vague.

YOUR ANSWER

What kind of political pressure does your romance need?

Think about the story you want to tell. Does your romance need a law that forbids it? A war that divides the lovers? A court that watches their every move? A class system that makes their love scandalous? Name the pressure, even if you don't yet know the details.

YOUR ANSWER

Politics in Romantasy

Politics in romantasy functions as external pressure, forces beyond your characters' control that forbid, compel, or complicate their relationship. Unlike internal obstacles (fear, trust issues, personal history), political obstacles exist whether your characters want them to or not.

Political pressure works on romance in three ways:

Politics as Prohibition

Laws and political structures that forbid the relationship:

- Marriage laws that make their union illegal
- Class systems that make their relationship scandalous
- Species laws that criminalise their love
- Political enemies who can't be seen to fraternise

Politics as Compulsion

Political forces that push characters together against their will:

- Arranged marriages for alliance or peace
- Political necessity requiring cooperation
- Shared enemies creating forced alliance
- Diplomatic situations demanding proximity

Politics as Stakes

What characters risk by pursuing the relationship:

- Execution, imprisonment, exile for illegal unions
- Loss of title, inheritance, political position
- War, broken treaties, political chaos
- Harm to family, faction, or nation

The most compelling political obstacles are ones characters can't simply ignore or talk their way out of. The law doesn't care that they're in love. The war doesn't pause for their feelings. The political marriage is happening whether they want it or not.

From Political Pressure to Romantic Tension

The trick to making politics serve your romance is understanding that every big political event needs a personal emotional consequence for your characters. A war isn't just a war. It's the reason he can't sleep beside her without flinching. A trade embargo isn't just economics. It's the reason she has to choose between feeding her people and protecting the man who controls the supply lines.

MACRO POLITICAL STAKE	MICRO ROMANTIC OBSTACLE
Global war or conflict	Vulnerability feels like political treason. Letting your guard down could get your people killed.
Theocratic law or doctrine	The act of intimacy is criminalised by the state. Desire itself becomes a sin.
Class or caste divide	The couple must sacrifice their status or safety to be together. One world must be abandoned.
Fragile court alliances	The relationship is under constant public scrutiny. Every glance is analysed for political meaning.
Resource scarcity or economic pressure	Trust is inhibited by the need for national survival. Love competes with duty to the starving.

In the strongest romantasy, your characters are changed by both the romance and the political conflict working together. The love interest provides the emotional safety or vulnerability needed for the protagonist to face their internal wound, while the political conflict provides the impossible challenge that forces them to find their strength. These two catalysts work in tandem. If your character only grows through love, the political plot feels decorative. If they only grow through political conflict, the romance feels bolted on.

Political Situations That Create Romance

PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES
The forbidden union	Law prohibits their marriage	Secrecy, risk, “us against the world”
The arranged marriage	Political necessity forces them together	Forced proximity, duty vs. desire
The enemies	Their peoples/factions are in conflict	Loyalty tested, betrayal required
The political prize	One is valuable for political marriage	Competition, commodification, rescue

PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES
The hostage/ward	One is held by the other's people	Power imbalance, Stockholm dynamics
The succession crisis	Their relationship affects who rules	High stakes, public scrutiny
The peace treaty	Their union could end a war	Pressure to perform, symbol vs. person

Political Character Pairings

PAIRING	BUILT-IN TENSION	KEY QUESTION
Royal + Commoner	Class law, succession, scandal	Can love override duty to bloodline?
Enemy nations	War, loyalty, treason	Can they choose each other over their people?
Conqueror + Conquered	Power imbalance, historical wrong	Can there be love without freedom?
Political rivals	Competing goals, zero-sum game	What would they sacrifice to win, or to love?
Arranged spouses	Obligation without choice	When does duty become desire?
Guard + Protected	Professional boundary, power difference	Can duty and love coexist?

Common Mistakes

Mistake #1: The Toothless Law

There's a law against their relationship, but nobody enforces it. They're "forbidden" but face no real consequences. Forbidden love only matters if the forbidding has teeth.

FIX

Show enforcement. Someone else has been punished. Getting caught would mean concrete, serious consequences. In *Serpent & Dove*, the law against witchcraft has real teeth because we see other witches burned. Lou doesn't just risk disapproval; she risks being set on fire by the man she's falling for. That's a law with consequences, and it's why the forbidden love in that story actually feels forbidden.

Mistake #2: The Easily Escaped Arrangement

One character is in an arranged marriage, but they can simply refuse, or the other betrothed is cartoonishly evil so breaking the arrangement is obviously right. Arranged marriage tension requires the arrangement to be genuinely binding. If the arranged partner is a moustache-twirling villain, there's no real dilemma. The reader knows our protagonist should leave, and the tension evaporates.

FIX

Make the arrangement matter. Breaking it means war, family ruin, or personal destruction. And make the arranged partner human, maybe even decent. The hardest choices aren't between good and evil. They're between two things that both have legitimate claims on your character's loyalty. Make the choice genuinely hard.

Mistake #3: The Vague or Vanishing Politics

There's political conflict, but it's unclear what anyone wants, what the stakes are, or why it matters. Or: serious political conflicts somehow stop mattering when the romance heats up. External pressure disappears when it's inconvenient. If readers don't understand the political situation, they can't feel the pressure on the relationship. And if that pressure lifts the moment the leads start falling for each other, the stakes feel fake. Readers need to believe the world would genuinely punish these characters if they're caught. **Quick check:** **Does your story fall into any of these traps?** | Mistake | Does It Apply? | How You'll Fix It | |----|-----|-----| | Toothless law (forbidden but no real consequences) | | | Easily escaped arrangement (obvious that they should leave) | | | Vague/vanishing politics (unclear stakes or pressure disappears) | | |

FIX

Be specific about who wants what and why both sides can't have it. Ground the conflict in concrete goals and consequences. Then keep the pressure on. Politics should intensify during the romance, not pause. The war doesn't stop because they're falling in love. The betrothal doesn't dissolve because they've had a meaningful conversation. The law doesn't look the other way because the reader wants them to be happy. If anything, the deeper they fall, the more dangerous their situation becomes.

Forms of Government

Different political structures create different pressures, different power dynamics, and different possibilities for your characters. The form of government you choose isn't just a worldbuilding decision; it determines what kind of romantic obstacle your story can sustain. A monarchy creates succession drama and forbidden love across ranks. An empire puts your characters in different conquered regions with different loyalties. In a theocracy, your characters' love may be considered a sin because of the nature of the religion they're living under. Choose the government that creates the pressure your romance needs.

The government type you choose shapes what kind of romantic obstacle your story can sustain. In *The Cruel Prince*, Elfhame's monarchy transfers power through cunning and murder, not just bloodline, which means Jude's mortal status isn't just socially awkward; it's a political death sentence that makes her romance with the prince an act of defiance against the entire system. In *Bridgerton*, the ton is like a small oligarchy of social power, marriage is a currency and every ball is a marketplace and a single scandal sheet can ruin a woman's future. It doesn't require a throne for the system to be an iron cage.

You can mix and match elements or take into consideration regional differences. Think about how this system creates obstacles for your romance.

Political divisions between countries can keep lovers separated or provide escape routes for them. If your characters needed to leave, where could they go?

♦ Core: What form of government exists in your world?

Common options: monarchy (absolute, constitutional, hereditary, elected), theocracy, magocracy, oligarchy, democracy, empire, feudal system, tribal confederation, council, or dual systems where magical and mundane authorities coexist.

YOUR ANSWER

How does your government make decisions day-to-day?

Does the ruler decide everything personally, or are there councils, advisors, or local governors? How much power reaches the average village or city district?

YOUR ANSWER

If your world has multiple nations, do they have different systems?

Political differences between nations can keep lovers separated, or provide escape routes. If your characters needed to flee, where could they go? If they come from nations with opposing systems, that's a built-in source of conflict.

YOUR ANSWER

How are borders controlled?

Can people move freely between regions or nations? Do they need papers, permits, or magical clearance? Who gets stopped and who passes through unchecked?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your government type create the romantic obstacle?

You chose this government for a reason. What specific pressure does it put on your characters' relationship that a different system wouldn't?

YOUR ANSWER

Cross-check: Does your government type match your economic system (Section 4)? A feudal monarchy with a free-market economy, or a democracy with serfdom, needs an explanation. Make sure these two systems reinforce each other.



You've chosen how your world is governed. Now let's look at who sits at the top of that system, because the person in power decides what threatens them, and your characters become a threat the moment their relationship crosses one of those lines.

Current Rulers

♦ Core: Who currently holds power?

The ruling body's priorities determine what threatens them, and your characters become a threat the moment their relationship conflicts with those priorities.

Name your current ruler(s)

Be specific: name or title:

YOUR ANSWER

How long have they ruled?

HOW LONG HAVE THEY RULED?

♦ Core: How did they gain power?

This matters because it reveals what they fear losing:

Inheritance (fears other heirs, revolution), conquest (fears being conquered), election (fears losing support), magical strength (fears stronger mage), divine right (fears religious challengers), coup (fears the same), marriage alliance (fears spouse's family).

YOUR ANSWER

How do they maintain power?

Military force? Magic? Religion? Economic control? Information and spies? Fear? Legitimacy and tradition?

YOUR ANSWER

What do they want?

The ruler's priorities determine what threatens them, and your characters become a threat the moment their relationship conflicts with those priorities. What does the ruler want badly enough to destroy a love story over?

YOUR ANSWER

What threatens their rule?

Every power structure has cracks. Rival claimants? Popular unrest? External enemies? Succession crisis? Prophecy?

YOUR ANSWER

♦ Core: How can a ruler be removed from power?

Assassination? Election? Revolt? Magical challenge? A council vote? Or is there no legitimate way, meaning the only path is violence?

YOUR ANSWER

♦ Core: What do ordinary people think of their government?

Do they trust their rulers, fear them, ignore them, or quietly resent them? How do common people talk about the government when no one important is listening?

YOUR ANSWER

How does this instability affect your characters' relationship?

Are your characters on opposite sides? Could their union stabilise or destabilise the realm? Would their relationship be used as a political weapon?

YOUR ANSWER

How Laws Work

Knowing how laws are created, changed, and enforced will tell you what obstacles are truly immovable and which might bend. This matters for your romance because it determines whether your characters have any path other than defiance. If laws can be changed by petition, there’s hope. If they’re magically bound into the foundations of the world, your characters are up against something that can’t be argued with.

When you’re writing scenes involving law, don’t have characters explain the legal system to each other. Instead, show what the law does to people. A character who flinches when guards pass, who hides a ring, who lies about their name at a checkpoint. That tells the reader everything about how the law works without a word of exposition.

Ruler by decree? Legislative body? Religious authority? Tradition that nobody changes? Magical compulsion? Divine law, ancient compacts, magically binding treaties, things that can’t be altered. Those are your most powerful romantic obstacles because no amount of political manoeuvring can remove them. Your characters must either break them, find a loophole, or accept them.

Who makes laws?

This determines whether your characters have any hope of changing the system that keeps them apart.

Ruler by decree? Legislative body? Religious authority? Tradition that no one changes? Magical compulsion?

YOUR ANSWER

Can laws be changed? How?

METHOD	HOW IT WORKS	HOW DIFFICULT
Ruler’s decree		

METHOD	HOW IT WORKS	HOW DIFFICULT
Legislative process		
Religious reinterpretation		
Revolution/conquest		
Legal challenge/appeal		

Are there laws considered unchangeable?

Divine law, ancient compacts, magically binding treaties. Things that *can't* be altered:

YOUR ANSWER

♦ Core: Which law most directly affects your characters' relationship?

This is the law your reader needs to feel. Name it specifically: the law that makes their love dangerous.

YOUR ANSWER

◆ **Core: How are laws enforced day-to-day?**

Think about what a regular person encounters. Are there guards on every corner, or does the law only show up when someone reports a neighbour? Do people follow the law out of respect, fear, or habit?

YOUR ANSWER

◆ **Core: What happens when an ordinary person breaks a minor law?**

A fine? Public shaming? A beating? Nothing, unless someone important notices? The everyday consequences tell your reader more about the system than any grand punishment.

YOUR ANSWER

How do ordinary people settle disputes with each other?

If two merchants disagree over a contract, or two families feud over land, where do they go? A local magistrate? A village elder? A temple? Trial by combat? Or do they handle it themselves?

YOUR ANSWER

♦ **Core: What rights do ordinary citizens have?**

Can they own property, travel freely, speak against the government, refuse to serve? What protections do commoners have that nobles or elites don't need, and what protections do they lack?

YOUR ANSWER

What do people owe their government?

Taxes, labour, military service, tithes, magical tribute? What does the government take from ordinary people, and what do people get in return? This shapes whether your characters see the government as protector or parasite.

YOUR ANSWER

What does corruption look like in your world?

Bribing a guard to look the other way? Nobles buying verdicts? Officials skimming taxes? Corruption can be your characters' greatest obstacle or their best escape route.

YOUR ANSWER

Political Hierarchy

Hierarchy is shown by how characters act, not what they say: who waits, who speaks first, who sits while others stand. Romantic tension in hierarchical gaps happens when the normal rules break: the powerful person asks instead of orders, and the powerless person refuses to submit.

◆ **Core: What's the political hierarchy?**

Map it from highest to lowest power. For each level, think about the physical behaviours that show rank: who waits, who speaks first, who can interrupt. These details will make hierarchy visible in your scenes without exposition.

YOUR ANSWER

What physical behaviours show rank in your world?

Who bows and who doesn't? Who speaks first? Who sits while others stand? Who can touch whom? These small details will make hierarchy visible in your scenes without exposition.

YOUR ANSWER

How do people move up (or down) in political power?

Birth? Achievement? Magical ability? Wealth? Military service? Marriage?

YOUR ANSWER

What key political positions exist in your world?

List the roles that matter for your story: advisors, generals, high priests, council members. For each, note what power they hold and who currently fills the role.

YOUR ANSWER

Who in the hierarchy would have the power to help or hinder your characters?

Think about who could grant permission, look the other way, or make their lives impossible.

YOUR ANSWER



◆ Checkpoint: Power Structure

Pause and look at your answers so far. Does your form of government logically produce the kind of ruler you described? Does the hierarchy you mapped match the way your ruler maintains power? If something doesn't fit, adjust before moving on.



You've defined who rules and how power is structured. Now let's zoom in on what government actually feels like for ordinary people, because your characters live in this system every day, not just during the dramatic moments.

Governance in Daily Life

Beyond the dramatic conflicts of succession and forbidden love, governments affect ordinary people through taxation, public services, and local administration. These details make your world feel lived-in and can create pressure on your characters in quieter but no less important ways.

How does the government fund itself?

Taxes, tithes, tribute, corvée labour, magical extraction? Who pays the most, and who avoids paying? How do people feel about it?

YOUR ANSWER

Who matters more to ordinary people: the central government or local authorities?

A distant king may be irrelevant compared to the village magistrate or regional lord who actually enforces the rules. Where does real, day-to-day power sit?

YOUR ANSWER

What civic institutions exist, and who controls them?

Schools, hospitals, public works, orphanages, postal systems, roads. Are these run by the state, religious orders, guilds, or private wealth? What happens if your characters need one of these institutions and can't access it?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your world handle diplomacy and foreign relations?

Are there ambassadors, trade agreements, or magical treaties? Could your characters use diplomatic channels, or be blocked by them? How do relationships between nations affect ordinary people's lives?

YOUR ANSWER

Magic & Political Power

Who holds magic determines who rules and who your characters are allowed to love. Magic can support or challenge existing power structures, and the imbalance doesn't evaporate because your characters are in love. Your mage may not realise they're creating fear, and the non-mage may never feel fully at ease.

Who controls access to magic?

Is it hereditary (bloodlines hold power)? Learned (those controlling education hold power)? Granted by deities (those controlling access hold power)? Random (those who find and control magic-users hold power)?

YOUR ANSWER

Do mages rule, serve rulers, or oppose rulers?

Mages rule (magocracy): How do non-mages fit in? What happens to weak mages?

Mages serve: Are they conscripted, employed, or enslaved? What happens to those who refuse?

Mages are controlled: What laws restrict magic? How are mages tracked or eliminated?

Which dynamic exists, and how does it affect your characters?

YOUR ANSWER

Can magical power be taken away, and by whom?

If the government can strip someone's magic, that's one of the most powerful threats in your world. If no one can, mages may be nearly ungovernable.

YOUR ANSWER

What laws govern magic use?

What's forbidden? What's required? What's regulated?

YOUR ANSWER

If one character has magic and the other doesn't, how does this affect their political standing?

IF ONE CHARACTER HAS MAGIC AND THE OTHER DOESN'T, HOW DOES THIS AFFECT THEIR POLITICAL STANDING?

Could your characters' relationship threaten the magical power structure?

Mixing bloodlines? Teaching forbidden magic? Creating a dangerous bond? Fulfilling or defying prophecy?

YOUR ANSWER



You've established what the laws are. Now comes the question that matters most for your romance: what happens when those laws are broken?

Law Enforcement & Justice

The greater question isn't "what's against the law?" but "what happens if they're caught?" The degree to which law is enforced shapes the texture of your romance. Omnipresent enforcement turns every stolen glance into a risk; weak enforcement means danger comes in sudden, devastating bursts after weeks of false safety.

♦ Core: Who enforces the law?

Royal guard? City watch? Magical enforcers? Religious authorities? Secret police? Self-enforcing magical contracts?

YOUR ANSWER

Who controls the enforcers?

Do they answer to the ruler, a council, the church, or themselves? The person who commands the guards is often more powerful than the person who writes the laws.

YOUR ANSWER

How effective is enforcement?

Omnipresent (high risk)? Moderate? Weak or corrupt (easy to evade)? Selective (depends who you are)?

YOUR ANSWER

Cross-check: Does your technology level (Section 9) support this kind of enforcement? Omnipresent surveillance requires infrastructure, magical or technological. If your world lacks both, enforcement will be patchy by default.

What happens when your characters are caught?

SITUATION	CONSEQUENCE
<i>Example: First offence (Serpent & Dove)</i>	<i>Suspicion, investigation by the Church, social scrutiny</i>
First offence	
Caught together	
Marry illegally	
Produce children	

♦ **Core: How does the justice system work?**

Who judges the accused? A monarch, a magistrate, a council, a mob? Do people get trials, or are punishments handed down on the spot?

YOUR ANSWER

What rights does an accused person have?

Can they speak in their own defence? Call witnesses? Appeal the verdict? Or does the judge's word end it? Think about whether the wealthy can buy better justice than the poor.

YOUR ANSWER

Is justice equal?

Does class, wealth, species, or magical status affect how law applies? Be specific about who gets treated differently:

YOUR ANSWER



Unequal Justice

One character may receive a slap on the wrist while the other receives a death sentence for the same offence. When someone says “let’s take this risk together,” they aren’t truly sharing the risk. The vulnerable partner is always calculating; the protected partner carries guilt for benefiting from a system that would destroy the person they love. In *Serpent & Dove*, Lou will burn alive while Reid will face shame and banishment. They’re never sharing the same level of risk, and that asymmetry creates distance even in their closest moments.

Are laws enforced equally, or does power matter?

Does the noble face consequences, or only the commoner? Can the magical character escape while the non-magical suffers?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the character who risks more feel about the one who risks less?

Does the protected character understand what the other faces? Do they try to shield them? Does the vulnerable character resent the inequality?

YOUR ANSWER

Could the protected character sacrifice their protection for the other?

Renounce their status? Confess to share punishment? What would that cost?

YOUR ANSWER

What would happen if only one of them were caught?

Would the protected character let the other suffer alone? Would they come forward? Would they have the power to save them?

YOUR ANSWER



Diplomatic Protection & Special Status

Some positions grant immunity from normal laws, or make someone untouchable in ways that affect the relationship.

Does either character have special legal status?

Diplomatic immunity? Religious sanctuary? Royal protection? Magical immunity? Status as hostage or ward?

YOUR ANSWER

How does this status affect what they can do, or what can be done to them?

Special status can be both shield and cage. What freedoms does it grant, and what constraints does it impose?

YOUR ANSWER

Could their status protect the other character?

Could marriage, alliance, or association extend protection to their partner?

YOUR ANSWER

Could their status endanger the other character?

Does being connected to them make their partner a target? Create political complications?

YOUR ANSWER

What would they lose if they gave up their special status?

Could they renounce it? At what cost?

YOUR ANSWER



Trials & Justice

If caught, do your characters get a trial?

A trial creates narrative opportunity for public confrontation, defence, and dramatic revelations.

YOUR ANSWER

Who judges them?

Monarch? Court? Religious authority? Magical council? Trial by combat?

YOUR ANSWER

Can they appeal? Is there any legal recourse?

Hope of appeal can drive plot; no recourse raises the stakes considerably.

YOUR ANSWER

Who would or could defend them?

Allies willing to speak for them reveal the depth of support or isolation your characters face.

YOUR ANSWER



Power Gaps & Intimacy

A gap in political power doesn't disappear because characters are in love. The issue isn't whether there is a power gap, but how your characters manage it and how you demonstrate to the reader that the less powerful character is making their own decisions. Three craft techniques worth knowing: **The rhetoric of choice:** the powerful character gives real choices, not commands disguised as suggestions (Rhysand continually offers Feyre choices; Tamlin removes them). **The equaliser arc:** the less powerful character has their own source of strength, so intimacy reads as choice rather than survival (Jude's ability to lie becomes her weapon; Poppy is a skilled warrior who could fight her way out). **The internal monologue as agency:** the reader sees the character actively weighing and deciding, not being swept along.

Who holds more power in the relationship?

Name the imbalance specifically: political rank, magic, wealth, legal standing.

YOUR ANSWER

What happens if the less powerful character says no?

If saying no leads to punishment, exile, or death, you don't have a romance. You have coercion. The reader must believe "no" is a real option. Does the more powerful character recognise the gap?

YOUR ANSWER

How will you show the reader that the less powerful character is choosing freely?

CRAFT TECHNIQUE	HOW YOU'LL USE IT	EXAMPLE
Rhetoric of choice (powerful character gives real choices)		<i>Rhysand offers Feyre choices: to train, to fight, to govern, to leave</i>
Equaliser arc (less powerful character has their own source of power)		<i>Jude's ability to lie becomes her weapon in a world of Fae who can't</i>
Internal monologue as agency (reader sees the character actively deciding)		<i>Poppy weighs her desires before acting on them</i>

The power doesn't have to be equal, but it has to be real. A character who has no power at all and no option to leave isn't in a position to consent, and your reader will feel that.

Marriage Laws

Marriage law is often romantasy's primary legal barrier. Marriage laws exist to maintain power structures, dictate inheritance, keep classes or species separate, or enforce religious belief. Knowing the purpose behind the law tells you how rigid it is. Show the law's impact through what it costs: lovers forced apart at the altar, a guest list requiring Crown approval, a wedding ceremony that includes a loyalty oath to the state.

♦ Core: Who can legally marry whom?

Consider restrictions based on class, species, magical status, gender, family, religion, age, political status:

YOUR ANSWER

Why do these restrictions exist?

Give a reason, even if it's a bad one. Magical danger? Political control? Religious doctrine? Maintaining class system? Historical catastrophe blamed on forbidden unions?

YOUR ANSWER

What makes a marriage legal and binding?

Religious ceremony? Legal contract? Magical binding? Consummation? Public declaration? Parental consent?
Royal approval?

YOUR ANSWER

Can marriages be dissolved?

Divorce allowed? Annulment possible? Magical bonds breakable? Or is marriage permanent?

YOUR ANSWER

What are the consequences of an illegal marriage?

Criminal (execution, imprisonment, exile)? Social (loss of title, disownment)? Magical (loss of power, curse)?
Political (loss of succession rights, treaty violation)?

YOUR ANSWER

Cross-check: Do these marriage laws match your cultural marriage customs (Section 3)? If your culture celebrates love matches but the law demands arranged marriages, that tension is great, but make sure it's intentional, not a contradiction.

Class & Caste

Class divisions establish many of romantasy's most difficult barriers. The prince and the servant, the noble and the commoner. The reason class divides are such powerful obstacles is because of their structural nature, not the personal.

A large part of why class-based relationships are compelling is due to the differences in worldview. The noble has never been concerned with where their next meal will come from; the servant has never been able to afford the luxury of boredom. The experiential differences created by a class gap will result in misunderstandings, fascination, and conflict.

Class also defines an individual in a way that continues long after they become romantically involved with someone from a different class. When the servant marries the prince, that servant remains someone who was raised to serve. The best examples of class-based romantic obstacles involve individuals experiencing the differences between two worlds without pretending that those two worlds are comparable.

In *ACOTAR*, Feyre is brought to the Spring Court from such extreme poverty that she can't even read. She has no knowledge of the customs of the court, doesn't know which fork to use, and has no idea how to interact with a world where people can afford the luxury of boredom. This class barrier doesn't disappear once Feyre and Tamlin fall in love. Instead it influences each of their interactions, each misunderstanding, every moment that Tamlin takes for granted something Feyre has never known. In *Bridgerton*, the Sharma family must navigate a class system they weren't born into, a system in which knowledge of the rules is as important as the money one possesses, and one misstep in etiquette could destroy all that they've worked for.

What social hierarchy exists?

Map it from highest to lowest, including what determines class (birth, wealth, magic, achievement):

YOUR ANSWER

Where do your characters fall in this hierarchy?

The larger the gap, the greater the romantic tension.

YOUR ANSWER

What does each character take for granted that the other has never experienced?

The noble who has never worried about a meal; the servant who has never had a free afternoon. These everyday assumptions create misunderstandings and fascination.

YOUR ANSWER

How many ranks separate them?

Same social class? One or two classes apart (scandalous but possible to bridge)? An extreme class gap (servant/royal)?

YOUR ANSWER

What laws enforce class separation?

Are there restricted areas or forbidden contact? What are the consequences if someone behaves above their station?

YOUR ANSWER

Can someone move between classes, and how?

Marriage, wealth, magic, military service, education? Or is the system locked at birth? If there is a path upward, your characters might have hope. If there isn't, they're fighting the system itself.

YOUR ANSWER

What social consequences exist for cross-class relationships?

Will they lose their status? Be disowned? Become socially isolated?

YOUR ANSWER



Species & Race Laws

What species exist in your world?

WHAT SPECIES EXIST IN YOUR WORLD?

What legal restrictions exist between species?

Intermarriage? Mixed-species children? Enslaved or second-class species? Segregated territories?

YOUR ANSWER

If your characters are different species, what laws affect them?

IF YOUR CHARACTERS ARE DIFFERENT SPECIES, WHAT LAWS AFFECT THEM?

◆ **Checkpoint: Laws, Justice, and Social Barriers**

Pause and look at your answers so far. Do the laws you defined match the enforcement system you described? If your world has strict marriage laws but weak enforcement, is that intentional, or a gap? Does your class system create a genuine barrier, or could your characters simply ignore it? If the obstacles feel too easy to overcome, strengthen them now.

Political Arrangements

Arranged marriages create forced proximity with high consequences. The characters didn't choose each other, but now they must live with each other. The tension lies in the gap between obligation and desire: can anything real develop in soil that wasn't intentionally selected?

Is one or both characters in an arranged marriage or betrothal?

If yes:

Who arranged it and why?

Family (for alliance, wealth, bloodline)? Ruler (for political stability)? Religious authority (fulfilling prophecy)?

The characters themselves made a deal?

YOUR ANSWER

What makes the arrangement binding?

Legal penalties? Magical oath? Political necessity? Family pressure? No alternative?

YOUR ANSWER

Who is the arranged partner?

Are they decent (potential ally), cruel (clear villain), in love with someone else too (shared predicament), or the actual love interest (arranged marriage to lovers)?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens if the arrangement is broken?

War? Family ruin? Loss of protection? Magical backlash? Political chaos?

YOUR ANSWER



Already Bound

Sometimes the arranged marriage isn't something to get past. It's the premise. They're already married. The legal barrier is gone; the obstacle is internal: seeing each other as people rather than responsibilities, building trust where none exists, developing genuine feeling in what began as a transaction. In *Kingdom of the Wicked*, Emilia and Wrath are magically bound before either wants it, and the question isn't whether they can be together but whether being together can mean anything real.

If your characters begin the story already bound by political marriage:

How long have they been married?

Just wed? Months? Years of cold distance?

YOUR ANSWER

What were the circumstances of the wedding?

Did they meet before? Was one or both unwilling? Was there hope, dread, or resignation?

YOUR ANSWER

What's their relationship like at the start of the story?

Strangers? Polite distance? Active hostility? Tentative curiosity?

YOUR ANSWER

What does their marriage require of them publicly?

Must they appear united? Produce an heir? Attend functions together? Share chambers?

YOUR ANSWER

What private boundaries have they established?

Separate bedrooms? Limited conversation? Rules about what they will and won't share?

YOUR ANSWER

What begins to shift those boundaries?

What event, conversation, or realization starts changing how they see each other?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the obstacle now, if they're already married?

The legal barrier is gone, but what emotional, political, or personal barrier remains? Trust issues? One is in love with someone else? They're on opposite sides of a conflict? One holds a secret?

YOUR ANSWER

See also: Economy & Labour: Marriage as Economic Contract for the financial dimensions of arranged marriages.

Political Marriages & Treaties

When couples marry for politics, both become symbols as well as people. Being treated as a political pawn changes self-worth. You learn your value is determined by what you can achieve, not who you are. Political unions carry weight far beyond how the individuals feel about each other: their union could end wars or start them, and factions will either push them together or work to break them apart.

Is your characters' relationship politically important?

If yes:

What political problem does their union solve?

Ends a war? Unites rival houses? Fulfills prophecy? Secures resources?

YOUR ANSWER

Who benefits from their union, and why?

WHO BENEFITS FROM THEIR UNION, AND WHY?

Who is threatened by their union, and why?

WHO IS THREATENED BY THEIR UNION, AND WHY?

What happens if they refuse the political obligation?

WHAT HAPPENS IF THEY REFUSE THE POLITICAL OBLIGATION?

How does political pressure affect their emotional relationship?

Do they resent being forced together? Does duty make intimacy feel less genuine? Do they fall in love despite the arrangement, or struggle to trust what they feel because of it?

YOUR ANSWER

Performing the Relationship

Sometimes the political situation demands that your characters pretend. Pretend to be in love when they're not. Pretend to be strangers when they're not. Pretend to be enemies when they're falling apart inside. The distance between the public performance and the private truth is one of the most reliable generators of romantic tension in the genre, because every public interaction is charged with what they can't say and every private moment is haunted by what they have to pretend.

There's a psychological reason this works so well. When people repeatedly perform the behaviours of love in public, declaring their partner's virtues to a court, touching them protectively, gazing at them with apparent affection, their internal feelings start to shift to match. You can't pretend to be in love eight hours a day and remain entirely unaffected. Eventually the performance starts to feel real because the body doesn't know it's acting.

In *The Bridge Kingdom*, Lara marries King Aren as a professional assassin sent to destroy his kingdom from the inside out. Lara's "performance" as a devoted wife is constantly undercut by the reality that she creates with Aren as they move through the dangers of the world together. She was sent to destroy him; she ends up loving him instead. The tension builds because Lara's internal dialogue documents exactly when the mission cracks, and when she starts to see that the man she was supposed to kill is honourable, faithful, and nothing like her father said he would be.

In *Radiance*, Brishen and Ildiko were both used as pawns in a marriage of convenience to facilitate a trade agreement between two species that found each other disgusting to look at. The public face they put on as symbols of peace was in direct contrast to their private lives as outsiders in their respective families. The reason the romance works is because they develop a legitimate friendship first, utilising humour and honesty regarding their physical appearance to form an intellectual connection. Once they develop a friendship based on respect, the feelings of affection grow, and eventually so do the feelings of desire.

Are your characters performing a relationship for political purposes?

If yes:

What are the ground rules of the performance?

All fake relationships start with boundaries. The romantic tension comes from violating them. How much physical contact is allowed? What story do they tell the public? When does the act end? Is one secretly working against the other?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the first boundary violation?

The moment one character crosses the performance's limits (a touch that lingers, a defence that's too fierce, a compliment that's true) is your romantic turning point.

YOUR ANSWER

When does the performance become real?

At what point does one character realise they're reaching for the other's hand even though no one is watching?

YOUR ANSWER

Factions & Opposition

Your couple doesn't exist in a vacuum. Political factions may support or oppose them based on how the relationship affects larger power struggles. Factions turn a love story into a political event. The moment your characters' relationship becomes known, every faction recalculates. Some see opportunity: this union could tip the balance their way. Others see a threat that must be eliminated. Your characters stop being just two people in love. They become pieces on a board, and factions will try to play them whether they like it or not.

Focus on factions that would care about your characters' relationship, either to support or destroy it.

Court intrigue? Elections? Military power? Economic pressure? Magical conflict?

Factional loyalty creates another layer of obligation and potential betrayal in the romance.

Being on the same side creates shared purpose; being on opposite sides creates the richest enemies-to-lovers tension.

The moment of choosing love over loyalty is one of the most powerful beats in enemies-to-lovers. What would push them to it?

What major factions exist in your world?

For each faction, note who leads it, what they want, and where their power comes from (military, money, magic, popular support, etc.).

YOUR ANSWER

How do these factions compete for power?

Court intrigue? Elections? Military force? Economic pressure? Magical conflict? The methods they use will shape how your characters get caught in the middle.

YOUR ANSWER

Which faction does each character belong to or align with?

WHICH FACTION DOES EACH CHARACTER BELONG TO OR ALIGN WITH?

Are they on the same side, opposite sides, or unaligned?

Same side creates shared purpose; opposite sides creates enemies-to-lovers tension; unaligned means one or both will eventually be forced to choose. Each configuration generates different romantic pressure.

YOUR ANSWER

If on opposite sides, what would it take to betray their faction for each other?

IF ON OPPOSITE SIDES, WHAT WOULD IT TAKE TO BETRAY THEIR FACTION FOR EACH OTHER?



Political Enemies

Who has political reason to keep your characters apart?

Name specific people. What position do they hold, and what do they stand to lose if your characters unite?

YOUR ANSWER

What will this person do to stop them?

Threats, sabotage, legal action, violence? The more specific, the more real the danger feels.

YOUR ANSWER



Political Allies

Who supports your characters despite the political risk?

Name the ally. What position do they hold, and why do they help?

YOUR ANSWER

What does helping your characters cost this ally?

Allies who risk nothing feel like plot devices. What do they stand to lose by supporting the relationship?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there current factional conflict that affects your story?

Political instability creates both danger and opportunity. Could your characters use factional conflict to their advantage?

YOUR ANSWER

Court Politics & Intrigue

Courts represent the world where romantasy thrives. Wherever you find your characters, whether it's a Fae high court, a demon prince's hall, or a Regency ballroom, the court is a stage where every single interaction is both personal and political. So why do courts make such great romantic settings? Because everyone at court is "on stage," performing their roles, and the romantic tension arises from the disconnect between what they claim to be publicly and who they truly are privately. In a court setting, all eyes are on your characters, creating a constant sense of surveillance. Any small act of private truth performed in a court setting can become revolutionary due to this constant observation. A lingering look becomes a political statement. A dance can be a form of negotiation. One whispered word to the wrong person can be enough to topple an alliance or spark a war. In *ACOTAR*, Feyre and Rhysand attend the Court of Nightmares, which requires them to portray themselves as the wicked, untouchable High Lord and Lady. Feyre must fight the urge to say "thank you" to the servants, and therefore appear cruel, while Rhysand objectifies her in front of his enemies. Their performance is strategic: it keeps their enemies from discovering the private truth of Velaris. However, the tension generated comes from the emotional cost to Feyre and Rhysand, and the intimacy of being the only two individuals in the room who understand the truth. In *Bridgerton*, the London Season is a social whirlwind of balls and assemblies where young people are placed on exhibit. The rules for ballroom etiquette are rigid: men must ask to dance, women can only refuse to dance if she rejects all other dances offered, and there can be no physical contact outside of the momentary possibility of touching hands. Every dance is a spectator event, with chaperones and gossip columnists watching for even the slightest sign of scandal. If yes, consider how the court environment affects your characters. What role must they portray? What happens when the mask falls?

Masks

The mask is the main obstacle to an emotional connection in a court setting and also the primary source of suspense. All court characters wear a mask, and the romantic tension is created by the moments when those masks crack. Both leads in *The Cruel Prince* use cruelty as a shield. Cardan uses his casual cruel behaviour and bullying to hide his deep-rooted fear of being vulnerable and the abuse he experienced within his family. Jude wears a mask of complete coldness and calculated strategy to cover her mortal fragility. The romantic spark ignites in the moments these masks slip: when Cardan stops someone from hurting Jude and then quickly puts back on his mask of cruelty, or when Jude uses a kiss to test her power over him, whether she intends it as punishment or desire. In *Kingdom of the Wicked*, the names of the Seven Demon Brethren houses are titles of sin and serve as masks. Wrath isn't simply a name; it's a performance that hides his real name, his personal history, and his developing feelings for Emilia. The fact that characters must shut down their emotions to avoid detection from magical surveillance makes suppressing feelings a type of romantic torture. When a character shares a private truth with their love interest alone, the most powerful romantic moments occur. The mask remains intact for the sake of the court. It falls away in the space of a stolen moment, behind a closed door, or in the time between performances. This selective exposure of vulnerability is what builds intimacy. Unity?

Who else is at court, and what do they want?

Courtiers, advisors, rivals, servants, spies. The people surrounding your characters create the audience that makes every private feeling dangerous. Who is watching, and what are they looking for?

YOUR ANSWER

What mask does each character wear at court?

The romantic spark happens when masks crack. You need to know what each character is hiding before you can write the moments it slips.

YOUR ANSWER

What makes the mask slip?

Exhaustion? A threat to someone they care about? A moment of unexpected kindness? The crack in the mask is your romantic beat.

YOUR ANSWER

What court ritual creates romantic pressure for your characters?

Balls, coronations, tournaments. Public rituals force your characters into proximity under observation. The best romantic moments happen when the performance cracks during the event.

YOUR ANSWER

Where is the private space where the masks come off?

The contrast between public performance and private truth drives the romantic arc. Where can your characters be themselves?

YOUR ANSWER

Do your characters navigate court as partners or adversaries?

Partners build intimacy through shared burdens. Adversaries build tension through strategic counterplay. Both can lead to romance, but through very different paths.

YOUR ANSWER

What private signals have your characters developed?

A look, a gesture, a code word. Surviving court together creates shared language. These small, secret communications are some of the most romantic moments you can write. What signals do they use, and what do they mean?

YOUR ANSWER



◆ Checkpoint: Arrangements, Factions, and Court

Pause and look at your answers so far. If your characters have an arranged marriage, does the political system you built earlier explain why it can't simply be refused? Do the factions you identified have clear, specific reasons to care about your characters' relationship? If you have a court setting, does it connect to the power structure and laws you already defined? Tighten any loose threads before continuing.

Secrets & Espionage

Secrets in romantasy aren't side stories; they're obstacles to intimacy. Each time your character holds back some information from their romantic partner, it's an additional wall between them, and each time they reveal a secret it opens a doorway that can't be closed. The core tension is this: your characters require deception to survive politically and honesty to feel intimate. They can't have both. That's the engine. When a character is keeping their true identity from their love, the relationship is built upon a false foundation. The romantic partner loves the version of a person the other has presented to them, not the entire person. The individual keeping the secret is also the person least capable of experiencing true intimacy, because their authentic self is never fully present in the same space as their partner. In *Serpent & Dove*, Lou has kept her identity as a witch a secret from Reid, a Chasseur that's been trained to kill her people. Both Lou and Reid enter into a marriage based on strategy, but as genuine feelings begin to develop, Lou's secret starts to poison their relationship. Reid's love grows stronger than Lou's because she's always keeping something guarded. She can never be fully in the same room with him. Each intimate moment is tainted by the reality that he'd set fire to her at the stake if he were to discover what she really is. In *Fourth Wing*, Xaden only shares with Violet "what you need to know." Violet is forced to question Xaden to obtain additional information. He can't share everything with her because of her close proximity to the state, exemplified by her mother's position and her friend Dain's ability to read memories. Their relationship relies heavily on physical attraction to provide a release, since their intellectual and emotional communication is consistently interrupted by the political implications of their connection.

Is either character hiding their true identity?

If yes:

What are they hiding, and from whom?

WHAT ARE THEY HIDING, AND FROM WHOM?

Why are they hiding it?

Survival? Shame? A mission? The reason shapes whether the eventual reveal feels like betrayal or self-preservation.

YOUR ANSWER

What happens if they're discovered?

WHAT HAPPENS IF THEY'RE DISCOVERED?

How does the secret create a ceiling on intimacy?

A character hiding their identity can never be fully present with their partner. The secret sets a maximum depth the relationship can reach, and the reader should feel that ceiling. What moments of connection are cut short or made hollow because of what's being hidden?

YOUR ANSWER

Espionage as Proximity

What spying does for characters is put them in charged close proximity. Intelligence gathering involves being close, observing behaviour patterns, finding vulnerabilities. As soon as the intelligence-gathering targets the same individual as the character's potential love interest, the lines of distinction become blurred rapidly between professional surveillance and obsessive personal focus. In *The Cruel Prince*, Jude accepts membership into Prince Dain's intelligence organisation, the Court of Shadows, as a strategic move to gain leverage in a world where her mortality has made her extremely vulnerable. As a spy, she's required to observe the royal family closely, and through that observation she comes to know Cardan's private vulnerabilities: the abuse he endured, the isolation beneath his cruelty. The dynamic between them is fuelled by this difference in knowledge. Jude now understands the private pain Cardan has experienced, and that understanding is beginning to become entwined with her growing, unwanted desire for him. In *ACOTAR*, Feyre goes back to the Spring Court in *A Court of Wings and Ruin* to deliberately act as a spy and create events that will disassemble Tamlin's power from within. The difference that makes this a romantic beat is the comparison to her prior relationship: Tamlin used "safety" as a reason to control her, while Rhysand trusts her enough to share intelligence at a very high level and allows her to maintain complete autonomy over her decisions. Together they develop a deeper connection through the burden of strategy they share. The espionage serves not just the war plot; it demonstrates the equal partnership they have. Formally (as an assigned spy) or informally (watching, learning, figuring out who they really are)? When a spy finds out something that humanises their subject, something that causes them to see beyond the political role to the person beneath, that's one of the most powerful romantic beats in the genre. What does your character find out?

Is either character spying on or gathering intelligence about the other?

Espionage creates charged proximity. When your character is watching someone closely for strategic reasons, that observation often blurs into personal fascination.

YOUR ANSWER

What does your character discover that humanises their target?

The moment a spy sees past the political role to the person beneath is one of the most powerful romantic beats in the genre.

YOUR ANSWER

The Revelation

The moment a secret is revealed is the most structurally important romantic beat in any story built on hidden identities. It's the point where the relationship either deepens or shatters, and it forces both characters to choose what they value more: the safety of the lie or the risk of the truth.

In *Serpent & Dove*, when Reid discovers Lou is a witch, his first response is to declare they're "not really married." Both of them have to address their preconceived notions due to this revelation. But the story doesn't stop there. Reid's own identity crisis, discovering that he possesses magic himself, dismantles his certainty and forces him to choose between the Church's doctrine and the woman he loves. The revelation isn't a single moment; it's a cascade that strips away everything both characters thought they knew.

In *Fourth Wing*, the revelation that the Venin exist and that Navarre has lied for centuries is a seismic shift. But what nearly destroys the relationship is the discovery that Xaden knew Violet's brother Brennan was alive for six years while she grieved him. The political secret is forgivable. The personal betrayal, layered on top of the political one, is what turns the relationship from a forbidden romance into an ideological conflict.

Craft note: the most effective revelations aren't clean. They don't happen in one conversation. They cascade. One secret leads to another. The first revelation forces a re-evaluation; the second forces a crisis; the third forces a choice. With each layer stripped away, your characters are left standing in front of each other with nothing left to hide.

Early (and the story is about navigating the aftermath)? At the midpoint (raising the stakes for the second half)? At the climax (forcing the final choice)?

Voluntary confession? Accidental discovery? Betrayal by a third party? Forced by circumstances?

Some revelations deepen the bond. Some shatter it. Some do both at once. The answer depends on what was hidden, why it was hidden, and whether the one who lied can offer something more than "sorry."

Trust After Betrayal

After the big reveal, the heavy lifting begins. The cat's out of the bag. Now what? A great many romantasy novels will put the two main characters through a time of separation after the reveal: the third-act breakup. Not only is this dramatic, it provides a lot of room for character growth for each of them. The party who kept the secret has to come to terms with the damage their actions caused. The party who was deceived has to figure out if knowing why someone betrayed them is enough, or if they require some other type of reconciliation. In *Fourth Wing*, Violet comes to realise she's in the same boat with her friends that Xaden was in with her: lying to the people you love to protect them. That comparison doesn't take away from the betrayal, but it gives Violet a new way to view it. Their relationship grows into maturity when she goes from "you lied to me" to "I see why, and I am still hurt." Words aren't nearly as important as actions at this point. What tangible, concrete item can they provide? Just because you understand why someone acted a certain way, it doesn't mean you're automatically forgiving them. You can understand someone's motivations and still be hurt by what they did. However, most times, understanding is the first step. Usually the person who was deceived gains the upper hand morally, and the person who lied typically has their standing diminished. How does this shift affect the relationship going forward?

When in the story is the secret revealed?

Early (and the story is about the aftermath)? Midpoint (raising second-half stakes)? Climax (forcing the final choice)?

YOUR ANSWER

How is the secret revealed?

Voluntary confession? Accidental discovery? Betrayal by a third party? Forced by circumstances?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the revelation deepen or shatter the bond?

DOES THE REVELATION DEEPEN OR SHATTER THE BOND?

If your secret unravels in layers, map the cascade:

The most effective revelations aren't one conversation. They're a chain reaction. Each layer stripped away raises the stakes.

LAYER	WHAT'S REVEALED	WHAT IT FORCES
First revelation	Xaden knew about the Venin	Re-evaluation of everything he's said
First revelation		
Second revelation (deeper)		

LAYER	WHAT'S REVEALED	WHAT IT FORCES
Third revelation (forces the choice)		

What does trust look like after the betrayal?

Words aren't enough. What concrete action does the character who lied take to rebuild trust?

YOUR ANSWER

Warfare & Military

War is the most extreme form of political pressure. It will separate lovers, create impossible loyalty choices for characters, and put them on opposing sides. War also has a way of changing an individual, and characters who have experienced combat will take that experience into their relationships. The nature of the conflict sets limits to what's possible for your characters and the risks they take in being with one another. When you know the conflict, you'll know the costs your characters incur in choosing one another. Fragile peace has its own forms of tension. Can the choice of your characters for each other tip the scales towards war or lasting peace? Rationing? Curfews? Suspicion of outsiders? Refugees? Economic hardship? Absent family members? Volunteers? Conscripts? Nobility obligated to fight? Mercenaries? Magical warriors? A professional standing army? For whom? At what age? For how long? Can it be avoided, and if so how? Do people view those who serve honourably? Do they fear them? Pity them? Look down on them? Does this view vary based on rank? Service in the military provides duty that may oppose love as well as experiences that change a person. Absence and separation? Emotional distance and PTSD? Skills that are attractive but potentially frightening? Duties that conflict with love?

The State of Conflict

Is your world at war, at peace, or somewhere in between?

The state of conflict determines the risks your characters face for being together and the pressures that keep them apart or force them into proximity.

- Active warfare (battles happening now)
- Cold war (hostility without open conflict)
- Fragile peace (war recently ended or about to begin)
- Long peace (generations without major conflict)
- Perpetual low-level conflict (border skirmishes, raids, never fully resolved)

YOUR ANSWER

If at war: who's fighting whom, and why?

IF AT WAR: WHO'S FIGHTING WHOM, AND WHY?

If at peace: what threatens to break it? What tensions simmer beneath the surface?

IF AT PEACE: WHAT THREATENS TO BREAK IT? WHAT TENSIONS SIMMER BENEATH THE SURFACE?

How does the state of conflict affect daily life?

Rationing? Curfews? Suspicion of outsiders? Refugees? Economic strain? Absent family members?

YOUR ANSWER

Military Service

Who serves in the military?

Military service creates duty that competes with love, and shapes who your characters are allowed to associate with.

Volunteers? Conscripts? Nobility obligated to fight? Mercenaries? Magical warriors? A professional standing army?

YOUR ANSWER

Is military service required?

Mandatory service can separate lovers, delay unions, or create the very proximity that sparks the romance.

For whom? At what age? For how long? Can it be avoided, and how?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the social status of soldiers?

Honoured? Feared? Pitied? Looked down upon? Does it vary by rank?

YOUR ANSWER

Is either of your characters in military service?

If yes:

Which character serves, and what is their role or rank?

WHICH CHARACTER SERVES, AND WHAT IS THEIR ROLE OR RANK?

Why do they serve: by choice, obligation, or force?

WHY DO THEY SERVE: BY CHOICE, OBLIGATION, OR FORCE?

What have they seen or done that they carry with them?

WHAT HAVE THEY SEEN OR DONE THAT THEY CARRY WITH THEM?

If one character is a soldier, how does this affect the relationship?

Absence and separation? PTSD and emotional distance? Skills that are attractive or frightening? Duty that conflicts with love?

YOUR ANSWER

Cross-check: Is your military technology consistent with Section 9? If your world has medieval infrastructure but your army uses magical long-range communication or mass transport, explain how the military got access to technology civilians lack, or adjust.



Enemies Across Battle Lines

If your characters are on opposing sides of a war, choosing each other is treason. Both have been trained to distrust the other side, and each side's propaganda shapes what they believe before they ever meet.

Are your characters on opposite sides of a conflict?

If yes:

What is the conflict, and which side is each character on?

WHAT IS THE CONFLICT, AND WHICH SIDE IS EACH CHARACTER ON?

What does each side believe about the enemy?

Propaganda, stereotypes, justified grievances. What were your characters taught about the other side before they met?

YOUR ANSWER

What would each character's people say about them loving the enemy?

Traitor? Spy? Corrupted? Foolish? Understandable but forbidden?

YOUR ANSWER

What would it take for them to choose each other over their side?

What would they have to believe, learn, or experience?

YOUR ANSWER

Could their relationship end the conflict, or make it worse?

Does their union have political implications for the war?

YOUR ANSWER

The Violence They Carry

Has either character killed or been wounded in the conflict?

What happened, and how does it affect them now? Think about nightmares, flinching at certain sounds, difficulty with trust or intimacy.

YOUR ANSWER

Has either character lost someone to the conflict?

Who was lost, how did it happen, and how does it shape the way they see the enemy?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there blood between their peoples that can't be easily forgiven?

Atrocities, massacres, betrayals during the conflict:

YOUR ANSWER

Does one character bear responsibility (personally or ancestrally) for violence against the other's people?

DOES ONE CHARACTER BEAR RESPONSIBILITY (PERSONALLY OR ANCESTRALLY) FOR VIOLENCE AGAINST THE OTHER'S PEOPLE?

How do they navigate this?

Can there be forgiveness? Understanding? Or is this wound too deep?

YOUR ANSWER

Desertion & Defection

What happens to deserters in your world?

Execution? Imprisonment? Exile? Branded? Hunted?

YOUR ANSWER

Could either character desert or defect for the relationship?

What would push them to it? What would they lose?

YOUR ANSWER

If one defects to the other's side, how are they received?

Welcomed? Suspected? Used for information then discarded? Tested?

YOUR ANSWER

War's End

How might the conflict end?

Victory for one side? Negotiated peace? Exhaustion? Outside intervention?

YOUR ANSWER

Could your characters' relationship play a role in ending the conflict?

Symbol of unity? Marriage alliance? Proof that peace is possible?

YOUR ANSWER

What would peace cost?

What would each side have to give up or accept?

YOUR ANSWER

In peacetime, could they be together openly, or would old hatreds persist?

IN PEACETIME, COULD THEY BE TOGETHER OPENLY, OR WOULD OLD HATREDS PERSIST?

◆ Checkpoint: Secrets and Warfare

Pause and look at your answers so far. If a character is hiding their identity, does the justice system you built earlier explain why discovery would be devastating? If your world is at war, do the military obligations you described create a genuine barrier to the relationship, or just an inconvenience? Make sure the pressure is real before moving on.

Everything you've built so far (the government, the laws, the factions, the wars) now converges on the most personal question: what happens when two people who should be enemies fall in love?

Enemies to Lovers

To make enemies-to-lovers believable, you need real, structural reasons why these two people should hate each other, not misunderstandings that vanish once cleared up. Misunderstandings create obstacles that disappear; true hostility creates obstacles that require hard work, sacrifice, and transformation to resolve. That's what makes enemies-to-lovers satisfying: seeing two people work through real grievances, not discovering they never had any.

The Foundation: Why Are They Actually Enemies?

Which of these creates the conflict between your characters?

Check all that apply and note specifics:

☐

Opposing sides of a war or conflict

They or their peoples are literally trying to kill each other.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER

☐

Historical wrongs between their peoples

One group harmed the other in ways that haven't been forgiven.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER



Directly opposed goals

What one wants requires destroying what the other wants.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER

☐

One has power over the other (and has used it)

Master/slave, conqueror/conquered, oppressor/oppressed.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER

☐

One has personally harmed the other (or their loved ones)

Not their peoples. Them specifically. Direct personal injury.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER

☐

Fundamentally opposed beliefs or values

What one considers moral, the other considers evil.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER

☐

Competition for something only one can have

Throne, position, resource, territory. Winner takes all.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER

☐

One represents the system that oppresses the other

Even if they didn't create it, they benefit from and enforce it.

SPECIFICS

YOUR ANSWER

How many of these apply to your story?

1: You have a foundation. Consider whether it's strong enough.

2-3: Good complexity. Multiple layers of conflict.

4+: Rich enmity, but make sure it's not insurmountable.

The Legitimacy Test

Could a reasonable person, knowing what your protagonist knows, hate your love interest?

Not just dislike, *hate*. If the answer is no, your enmity isn't strong enough.

YOUR ANSWER

Could a reasonable person, knowing what your love interest knows, hate your protagonist?

Enemies to lovers works best when both have legitimate grievances.

YOUR ANSWER

Types of Political Enmity

Historical Enemies

What historical wrong exists between their peoples, and who did what to whom?

Be specific. Vague “ancient grudge” isn’t enough. Conquest? Massacre? Betrayal? Enslavement? Theft of land or magic?

YOUR ANSWER

How recent is this history, and what evidence remains?

Living memory or centuries ago? Scars on the land, displaced peoples, stolen artifacts, suppressed culture, ongoing inequality?

YOUR ANSWER

How does each character relate to this history?

Do they feel personal guilt or grievance, or do they see it as “the past”? Are they inheritor, victim, bystander, or denier?

YOUR ANSWER



Personal Enemies

What did one character do to the other (or their loved ones)? Was it intentional, justified (in their mind), or accidental?

WHAT DID ONE CHARACTER DO TO THE OTHER (OR THEIR LOVED ONES)? WAS IT INTENTIONAL, JUSTIFIED (IN THEIR MIND), OR ACCIDENTAL?

Does the one who caused harm feel guilty, justified, or conflicted?

DOES THE ONE WHO CAUSED HARM FEEL GUILTY, JUSTIFIED, OR CONFLICTED?

What would justice look like to the wronged party, and can this harm actually be forgiven? Death? Confession? Reparation? Some things can't be forgiven, and pretending otherwise insults readers.

YOUR ANSWER



Ideological Enemies

What belief does each character hold that the other finds repugnant, and what experiences or evidence support each view?

Not just “they were raised that way.” If one belief is clearly wrong, the story is about learning; if both have merit, it’s about synthesis or accepting difference.

YOUR ANSWER



The Path from Enemies to Lovers

What unexpected act first cracks each character's certainty about the other, and how do they explain it away?

WHAT UNEXPECTED ACT FIRST CRACKS EACH CHARACTER'S CERTAINTY ABOUT THE OTHER, AND HOW DO THEY EXPLAIN IT AWAY?

What does each character learn about the other's reasons that shifts their understanding, even if they don't agree?

WHAT DOES EACH CHARACTER LEARN ABOUT THE OTHER'S REASONS THAT SHIFTS THEIR UNDERSTANDING, EVEN IF THEY DON'T AGREE?

What does each character do that their side would consider betrayal, and what does it cost them?
Not just "has feelings". An action that crosses a line.

YOUR ANSWER



The Cost of Reconciliation

In the strongest enemies-to-lovers, both characters pay a real price for choosing each other. The cost should be high enough that their choice means something.

What does each character sacrifice to be together?

Be specific. Not just “status” but what that status meant to them. Community, family, identity, safety, purpose?

	WHAT THEY LOSE	WHY IT HURTS
Protagonist		
Love Interest		

Are these sacrifices roughly equal in weight?

If one gives up everything and the other gives up nothing, readers won't believe they're equals.

YOUR ANSWER



The Conversation That Has to Happen

What specifically needs to be addressed between them, and what does each character need to say and hear for reconciliation to be possible?

WHAT SPECIFICALLY NEEDS TO BE ADDRESSED BETWEEN THEM, AND WHAT DOES EACH CHARACTER NEED TO SAY AND HEAR FOR RECONCILIATION TO BE POSSIBLE?

Is there an apology? Is it sufficient? Is there forgiveness? Is it earned?

IS THERE AN APOLOGY? IS IT SUFFICIENT? IS THERE FORGIVENESS? IS IT EARNED?



What Can't Be Fixed

What damage from their enmity is permanent, and how do they live with it?

WHAT DAMAGE FROM THEIR ENMITY IS PERMANENT, AND HOW DO THEY LIVE WITH IT?

World Impact

Does their relationship affect the larger conflict?

Symbol of peace? Proof that reconciliation is possible? Catalyst for change? Or just two people who found each other despite everything?

YOUR ANSWER

How do others react to their relationship?

Think about both sides: the protagonist's people and the love interest's people. Do they accept it, condemn it, or try to use it?

YOUR ANSWER



Enemies-to-Lovers Pitfalls

Use this to pressure-test your enmity:

Check: Is your enmity based primarily on misunderstanding?

CHECK: IS YOUR ENMITY BASED PRIMARILY ON MISUNDERSTANDING?

Check: Does attraction make them forget their legitimate grievances?

CHECK: DOES ATTRACTION MAKE THEM FORGET THEIR LEGITIMATE GRIEVANCES?

Check: Do they ever actually address the reason they were enemies?

CHECK: DO THEY EVER ACTUALLY ADDRESS THE REASON THEY WERE ENEMIES?

Check: Does falling in love make either character unrecognizable?

CHECK: DOES FALLING IN LOVE MAKE EITHER CHARACTER UNRECOGNIZABLE?

◆ Checkpoint: Enmity and Romance

Pause and look at your answers so far. Is the enmity between your characters rooted in the political structures you built earlier, or does it float free of them? Can you trace a line from the government type, through the laws, through the factions or war, to the specific reason these two people are enemies? If the enmity feels disconnected from the world, anchor it now.

Succession & Heirs

Who your characters marry, whether they produce heirs, and which bloodlines those children carry all have political implications. Whether to have children is no longer a personal choice. It's being debated in council chambers by people who will never hold the child. That moment when your character realises their body has become a political resource is one worth writing carefully.

What does each character stand to inherit?

Throne, title, land, wealth, magical legacy? The bigger the inheritance, the more people will care who they marry.

YOUR ANSWER

How does their relationship affect inheritance?

Marrying wrong costs inheritance? They must marry to inherit? Their union combines inheritances?

YOUR ANSWER

Is either character expected to produce an heir?

Who is applying the pressure: family, court, law? Is there a deadline? What happens if they don't produce an heir in time?

YOUR ANSWER

If they're different species or one is sterile, how does this affect heir requirements?

IF THEY'RE DIFFERENT SPECIES OR ONE IS STERILE, HOW DOES THIS AFFECT HEIR REQUIREMENTS?

Could their relationship cause or solve a succession crisis?

COULD THEIR RELATIONSHIP CAUSE OR SOLVE A SUCCESSION CRISIS?

Revolution & Reform

Sometimes the only way to be together is to change the world. This transforms a love story into a political one. The lovers don't just want each other, they want to create a world where others like them can live openly. But revolution is never clean. It requires putting others at risk, making choices where someone gets hurt regardless, and the strongest romantasy won't let the couple emerge with clean hands.

Are there legal means to change the laws keeping them apart?

Appealing for exception? Changing laws politically? Waiting for a new ruler? Finding loopholes?

YOUR ANSWER

If peaceful change is impossible, what would revolution look like?

IF PEACEFUL CHANGE IS IMPOSSIBLE, WHAT WOULD REVOLUTION LOOK LIKE?

Who else would benefit from changing the system?

Your characters aren't the only ones suffering under these laws. Who are their potential allies, and what would those allies want in return?

YOUR ANSWER

Would your characters join or lead a revolution?

What would push them from surviving the system to fighting it?

YOUR ANSWER

What would they sacrifice to change the system?

Safety? Family? Status? Each other?

YOUR ANSWER

What's lost even if they win?

Revolution isn't clean. Lives lost? Stability destroyed? Becoming what they fought?

YOUR ANSWER

Apply the Iron Cage Principle

Now that you've built your political world (government, laws, rulers, factions, courts, and conflicts), return to the Iron Cage. Everything you've developed in this section should serve the cage around your romance. Use what you've built to answer these questions with specificity.

What is the iron cage around your romance?

The cage is the structural force that keeps your characters apart. Not a personal flaw or misunderstanding, but a system, law, or political reality that doesn't care about their feelings. Name it specifically.

YOUR ANSWER

Why can't your characters simply walk away from the cage?

An iron cage only works if leaving it would break something bigger than the relationship. What's at stake beyond the two of them?

YOUR ANSWER

Which type of political pressure operates in your story?

Most stories use more than one. Identify which apply and note the specifics.

PRESSURE TYPE	DOES IT APPLY?	HOW SPECIFICALLY?
<i>Prohibition (law forbids the relationship)</i>	<i>Yes: species law criminalises Fae/mortal unions</i>	<i>Marriage is void under Elfhome law; mortal has no legal standing</i>
Prohibition (law forbids the relationship)		
Compulsion (political forces push them together)		
Stakes (what they risk by being together)		

Map your political stake to a romantic obstacle:

Take the biggest political pressure in your story and translate it to the personal level. What does this political reality feel like in an intimate moment between your characters?

What is the biggest political pressure in your story, and what does it feel like during an intimate moment?

WHAT IS THE BIGGEST POLITICAL PRESSURE IN YOUR STORY, AND WHAT DOES IT FEEL LIKE DURING AN INTIMATE MOMENT?

What does the romance force your protagonist to face emotionally?

Your protagonist should grow through both the romance and the political conflict, not just one. If you can only fill in one of these, the other plotline may be decorative.

YOUR ANSWER

What does the political conflict force your protagonist to face?

WHAT DOES THE POLITICAL CONFLICT FORCE YOUR PROTAGONIST TO FACE?

Integration Check

How does government interact with magic in your world?

HOW DOES GOVERNMENT INTERACT WITH MAGIC IN YOUR WORLD?

What magical law most directly affects your characters?

WHAT MAGICAL LAW MOST DIRECTLY AFFECTS YOUR CHARACTERS?

Could magic bypass the political obstacles in your story?

If magic could solve the problem, you need a reason it doesn't: legal prohibition, personal cost, lack of access.

If the government uses magical enforcement (truth spells, tracking, binding oaths), that closes escape routes.

YOUR ANSWER

The Core Political Obstacle

In one sentence, what is the primary political obstacle keeping your characters apart?

IN ONE SENTENCE, WHAT IS THE PRIMARY POLITICAL OBSTACLE KEEPING YOUR CHARACTERS APART?

How can this obstacle be overcome?

- Changing who they are (gaining status, power, different identity)
- Changing the system (reform or revolution)
- Escaping the system (running away, exile)
- Accepting consequences (being together despite the cost)

Which path do your characters take?

YOUR ANSWER

When does the political obstacle force a choice?

The crisis point when they can no longer avoid confronting it:

YOUR ANSWER

Quick Reference: Political Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
The law(s) that forbid the romance	
Consequences if caught	
Who enforces and how aggressively	
Political enemy who opposes them	
Political ally who supports them	
State of conflict (war/peace)	
Military obligations affecting the romance	

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD
Source of genuine enmity (if enemies-to-lovers)	
What each loses by choosing the other	
The political crisis point	
How it resolves	



What's Next

You've built the political skeleton of your world: the power structures, laws, and conflicts that cage your romance. Here's where to go next depending on what you need:

- **Economy, Labour & Resources (Section 4)** if you haven't built it yet. Your government needs money, and your characters live inside an economic system that reinforces (or undermines) everything you just designed.
- **Culture, Customs & Daily Life (Section 3)** to flesh out the social rules that exist alongside your laws. Laws tell people what they *can't* do; culture tells them what they *shouldn't* do. The gap between the two is where some of your best tension lives.
- **Religion, Myth & Prophecy (Section 6)** if your government draws legitimacy from divine authority, or if prophecy plays a role in your succession or conflict.
- **History & Lore (Section 7)** to ground the political tensions you've created in historical events: wars, betrayals, and founding myths that explain why your world's politics feel the way they do.

- **Technology & Infrastructure (Section 9)** to make sure your enforcement systems, military, and communications are consistent with what your world can actually build and maintain.